

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Source: Our World in Data / IHME Global Burden of Disease, 2023

For public health policy analysts and mental health program planners

Hundreds of Millions Affected

Major Depression Lifetime Risk



1 in 3

women

will experience major depression
in their lifetime



1 in 5

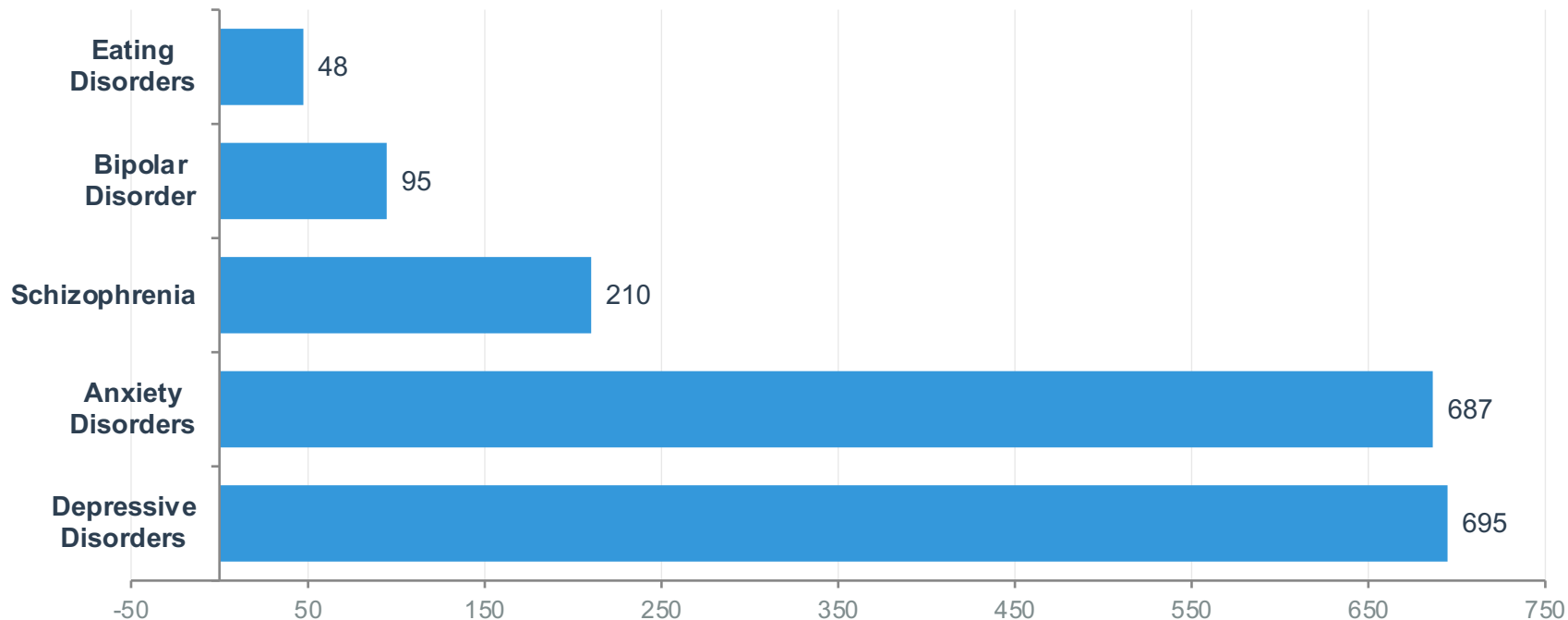
men

will experience major depression
in their lifetime

Other conditions such as schizophrenia and bipolar disorder are less common but carry severe individual impact.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate Disease Burden

DALYs per 100,000 people, World 2023



Source: IHME, Global Burden of Disease, 2023

Near-Equal Burden: Depression vs. Anxiety

Together they account for ~80% of mental health disease burden



694.6

DALYs per 100K

Depressive Disorders



686.5

DALYs per 100K

Anxiety Disorders

Only 1.2% difference in disease burden — nearly identical impact

Combined, depression and anxiety represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs worldwide.

Severe Conditions: High Individual Impact

Lower population prevalence but disproportionate individual disability



210.2

DALYs per 100K

Schizophrenia

Disproportionate burden relative to prevalence



94.6

DALYs per 100K

Bipolar Disorder

Severe disability with episodic patterns

While population-level burden is lower than depression/anxiety, individual severity and years lived with disability are high.

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking

The persistent gap between need and care



Stigma

Many people feel uncomfortable sharing symptoms with healthcare professionals



Access

Treatment often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries



Quality

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality



Underreporting

Discomfort with disclosure makes true prevalence hard to estimate

The actual burden of mental illness is likely higher than reported figures suggest.

How People Cope: Diverse Strategies Worldwide

Global survey data reveals wide variation in how people deal with anxiety or depression



Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings where healthcare systems provide pharmacological options



Religious / Spiritual

Prevalent in many regions worldwide, providing community support and meaning



Friends & Family

Widely reported coping mechanism across cultures and economic contexts

Policy must account for cultural, economic, and healthcare differences — no one-size-fits-all approach.

Key Takeaways for Policy

- 1 Depression and anxiety dominate mental health DALYs (~80% of burden)
- 2 Schizophrenia and bipolar carry disproportionate individual burden — specialized care essential
- 3 Treatment exists but access and quality remain inadequate — scaling is critical
- 4 Stigma suppresses help-seeking and accurate data — public education matters
- 5 Scale evidence-based interventions for common disorders while maintaining specialized care